

Transferable Skills for Physicists (TSfP)

PH4040 – Assignment 2: The Talk

1 Overview

The Talk (7% of Module Total)

Learning Outcomes Tested: Oral Communication (6), IT Proficiency (9)

Duration: 12–15 minutes

Audience: Your skills tutorial group — your Senior Honours peers and your tutor

Where and when: Week 5 (12–16 Oct), in your group's own sessions, in a room your group books at Skills Tutorial 2

Marking Breakdown: Technical Aspects (3.5%) | Scientific Competence (3.5%) — equally weighted halves of the 7%

Oral presentation skills are essential for all physicists. This assignment builds towards your Review Article and your future final-year project presentations. Your goal is to research a physics/astronomy topic and deliver a professional 12–15 minute slide-based presentation to your skills group.

2 Timeline and Deliverables

- **Week 2, Tuesday (5 pm), Skills Tutorial 1:** Talk your topic choice through with your skills tutor and the rest of your group. This topic will normally also become your Review Article topic, so choose something you are willing to live with for the semester.
- **Week 2, by Friday:** Your topic agreed with your skills tutor. No two people in your group may take the same one, so do not leave it to the last moment.
- **Week 2, Friday (10 am):** Whole-class session on researching and giving talks.
- **Week 3, Tuesday (5 pm):** Example talk by a previous student. Use it to reflect on how a talk is constructed.
- **Tue 6 October (10 am):** Submit your comments on the example talk via Moodle — the good points and the areas for improvement — so your group and tutor can read them before Skills Tutorial 2.
- **Week 4, Tuesday (5 pm), Skills Tutorial 2:** The example talk, unconscious bias, and your own talk preparation. You will book your presentation slot here.
- **Week 5 (12–16 Oct): Every talk is given in your skills tutorial group**, which meets two or three times that week so that everyone is heard. There is no separate venue or wider audience: you speak to the same four or five people you have been arguing with since Week 2, and your tutor. Expect questions from all of them immediately after your talk.

3 Presentation Guidelines

3.1 Content

- The topic must be relevant to Physics or Astronomy. Your talk topic will normally **also be your Review Article topic**, or a subset of it — the reading counts twice. If you want to change topic after the talk, that is possible by negotiation with the coordinator during Week 6.
- You should prepare slides (e.g., MS PowerPoint, Keynote, or LaTeX Beamer). Ensure all images or diagrams are appropriately cited on the slides.
- Pitch your talk at the level of your Senior Honours peers—assume foundational physics knowledge, but no specialist expertise in your specific topic.

3.2 Delivery

- The target length is strictly 12 to 15 minutes. Being under 10 minutes or over 17 minutes will incur significant penalties.
- You must be prepared to answer questions. Your mastery of the topic during the Q&A is a core component of the ‘Scientific Competence’ mark.

3.3 Where topics come from

Topics are taken from a **list of titles suggested by staff in the School**, published on Moodle as *PH3014 & PH4040 — Talk and Review Article Topics*. There are considerably more titles than there are students. Each was proposed by a member of staff who works in or near that area and who has agreed to be contacted about it, so once you have done some initial reading you have an expert you can go and ask – see the Review Article specification for how to approach them.

You may propose a topic of your own instead, but **only if your skills tutor agrees to it**. Bear in mind why the list looks the way it does: subjects such as superstrings or parallel universes are deliberately absent, because anything beyond a superficial treatment of them needs far more room than a 15-minute talk or a 2,500-word article allows. Whatever you pick, we are looking for real understanding and explanation of the underlying science, not coffee-table-book coverage, so choose something you can get into properly.

Two practical constraints. **No two people in your tutorial group may take the same topic**, so settle yours early rather than assuming it will still be free at the end of the week. And remember it normally carries forward into your Review Article – a specific, well-scoped question you are genuinely curious about will always make for a stronger talk, and a better article, than a broad, generic title.

3.4 On the day

The room your group books will have a PC and a data-projector or large screen, so you can present live from PowerPoint (or an equivalent). If you want to use presenter notes, check in advance how to enable an extended desktop / presenter view on the room’s machine – do this before your slot, not during it. Chairs will leave a short gap between talks for the group to note feedback before discussion begins.

4 Marking Rubric

The skills tutors are responsible for allocating the final mark, but you will also receive formative peer feedback on what went well and what could be improved. Markers are looking at: clarity of exposition and pitching for the audience; accuracy of the science; the difficulty of the subject relative to what you attempted; your ability to cope with reasonable questions; the quality and appropriateness of your visual aids; audibility, presence, confidence and enthusiasm; and timing. These map onto the two formal bands below: **Technical Aspects** and **Scientific Competence**.

Band	Technical Aspects (50%)	Scientific Competence (50%)
85%+ (High 1st)	Professional academic standard. Enthusiastic, engaging, and perfectly paced. No padding. Excellent, fully referenced slides.	Exceptional understanding; explains nuances clearly; handles questions excellently.
74%+ (1st Class)	Good presence, eye contact, and flair. Slides support the talk very well. Uses 12-15 min slot accurately.	Excellent understanding, perfectly pitched. No factual errors. Answers sensible questions well.
62–73% (2.1)	Reasonable skills but minor deficiencies. Lacks the "sparkle" of a first-class talk.	Good understanding; no significant errors; answers most questions satisfactorily.
50–61% (2.2)	Flow or pacing issues (too fast/slow or <12 mins). Weak slides or inappropriate engagement levels.	Too descriptive/advertising; inappropriate pitch; some factual errors. Difficulty with Q&A.
<50%	Significant delivery problems; major timing failures.	Significant factual errors; poor pitching; lacks knowledge beyond the script.